try to resolve the dispute diplomatically, while defending the border militarily.[81] Speaking to members of Congress, Eisenhower expressed the belief that the situation had made Nehru more realistic, with even Krishna Menon saying that Delhi might have erred on China.[82]

There was a sense that the boundary dispute was also shaping India's attitude toward the Tibetans. At an NSC meeting, Allen Dulles noted that increasing skirmishes and stronger Indian public sentiment seemed to have made Delhi "friendlier" toward the Dalai Lama.[83] The Indian government was still, however, reluctant to be more active on the Tibet question at the UN. As the British foreign secretary explained, the border dispute—and Soviet neutrality on that issue—only reinforced India's desire not to give Moscow a reason to take China's side. With allies also urging caution, the US decided to avoid a very public role, instead getting Ireland and Malaya to sponsor a resolution.[84]

The Far East bureau also recommended against recognizing Tibetan independence. It was unlikely that other countries would follow, which would not help the Dalai Lama.[85] Privately, Washington informed Indian, Taiwanese, and Tibetan officials that the US recognized the "principle of self-determination" for Tibetans. The US could not, however, recognize a Tibetan government-in-exile at that point. Responding to Tibetan pleas for Washington to push Delhi on this question, American officials asserted that India would not extend recognition.[86] Finally, given Indian concerns, the US turned down a request for the Dalai Lama to meet Eisenhower during the president's visit to India. The Indian foreign secretary was relieved, since a meeting would likely increase Chinese accusations of India-US collusion and consequently India's security problem.[87]

India appreciated American understanding of its Tibet sensitivities, but a statement in November by Secretary of State Herter raised questions about the administration's stance on the Sino-Indian boundary dispute. He noted at a press conference that while the US presumed that India's claims were "valid," it had "no objective basis for such a presumption." Herter added, "I don't think we have taken any sides in [the dispute] at all." Furthermore, he went on to say that he thought it was "probably correct" to say that the US "has no view whatsoever as to the rightness or wrongness of this issue."[88] The *New York Times* reported that American officials, journalists, and